temperature in the compartments on the B-59 was 45-50°C [113-122°F] and up to 60°C [140°F] in the engine compartment. With rising levels of carbon dioxide, 'people were dropping like dominoes.' [35] The temperature at which nuclear weapons are maintained is very carefully controlled. What was the temperature in the B-59 forward torpedo room? Was there risk of an explosion on a ship that did not normally carry nuclear ordnance and whose crew were unfamiliar with nuclear weapons safety? What thought had been given to such problems by the Soviet naval staff preparing the operation?

Notwithstanding failings in ExComm's scrutiny of the SSIP procedure, McNamara and Kennedy were greatly exercised about operational issues. The contrast with (what we know of) Soviet operations is apparent. The Sixty-ninth Brigade was intended to reach Mariel by 20 October (though orders were changed on 15 October, when it was instead directed to the Sargasso Sea). The submarines had to navigate Atlantic storms, Hurricane Ella, and then a tropical climate for which the Project 641s were not designed and the crews not prepared. Meeting the schedule meant travelling on the surface, where the submarines were vulnerable to the weather and US ASW aircraft. The captains were also required to adhere to a rigid communications schedule, regardless of the tactical situation. The Project 641 needed to be at periscope depth to receive and send messages. To do so risked detection.

As explained earlier, the SSIPs were ad hoc procedures. The submarines would know that explosive devices were intended to signal rather than sink them only if they were notified of the US navy's procedures. There are differing accounts of when the captains learned of these.

Serhii Plokhy states that on the B-59, Captains Savitsky and Arkhipov were aware of the surfacing procedures, but had difficulty distinguishing between the practice depth charges and real ones.[36] None of the submarines surfaced in response to the SSIPs, contrary to what the US navy maintained. Three of the four (B-36, B-59 and B-130) did surface in the presence of US warships, but this was because their diesel-electric engines needed to be recharged or repaired. The B-130 was indeed sufficiently crippled by its engine problems that it eventually needed towing back to port. The B-4,